



Recycling incentives...

NMagazines like ours maintain lists of possible subjects for articles, and during the last few weeks I noticed two suggestions from our team that seemed to me should fit together – an article on the science of climate change and one on the general topic of green computing or green tech. This thought occurred to me just as I had become aware of the recycling campaign of Nokia. Being a Sony Ericsson user, I hold no brief for Nokia, but the company's efforts seem certainly to be genuine and not just PR mush – which is my opinion of much of the green PR hype that I hear. The result is the article in this issue that takes a critical look at green technology.

Another incentive to tackle this subject was my experiences with meeting hardware companies here in India (and elsewhere). Many of them tout green benefits of one kind or another, and I have this very annoying tendency to want to know what is meant by such claims. The answers have mostly been rather weak, and suggested to me that these companies were simply jumping onto a bandwagon. Some have also been amusing. An IBM environmental specialist spokesman in Bangalore showed me a slide of the world on fire. When asked what this implied, he mentioned global warming, of course. When I challenged him with the simple fact that the world has recently been cooling, he told me that all the servers and hard drives we were using were warming up the atmosphere. It's so good to meet people with such sound logic and deep understanding of their subject!

On the issue of climate change I wrote a couple of years ago to the leader of the opposition in the UK. I expected him not to agree with my views, but that was not to my mind the most important thing that came out of this; I would have enjoyed a well-informed debate, if he had been willing. Instead, the answer that I received showed an appalling lack of knowledge of the subject and a seriously simplistic approach. If all our politicians are so badly informed, then we really are doomed. If this chap ever becomes Prime Minister of the UK, I think I shall publish his reply on the internet.

Are politicians equally badly informed when it comes to considering other issues, such as genetic modification of foods, cloning and embryonic research, terrorism and security, licensing of medical practices, car safety legislation, energy security, food safety standards, etc., etc.? It's a worrying thought.

The local government in the area of my London flat started a recycling scheme about fifteen years ago, for paper and glass. Each flat can request a box that you can fill, and

these will be emptied once a week. I was one of the first to sign up, and I noticed that the takeup was very slow, and even now many of the local homes do not bother. There is no incentive, and governments are now thinking of creating punitive incentives to force people to recycle. And as for e-waste...

The situation here in India is a little different, with the rag-picking economy that had an equivalent back in Europe many years ago. There is no incentive to stop just throwing things away because somebody else will come along and collect it and sell it. Others do recycle, but because of the same incentive - if you hoard your newspaper, old clothes, plastic bags, and so on, you can go and sell these.

What is actually needed, both here and in the rest of the world, is for people not to need an incentive, but to be careful with waste and to recycle relevant materials because they see this as a good thing to do. Make the odd buck or two if you can, by all means, but we need to kill of the throw-away society, completely.

There are two sides to this. The obvious one is to be careful with items that are no longer needed, and instead of just throwing them away, make sure that they are properly recycled. The other side to this concerns the decisions we make when purchasing new products. It would help apply pressure to the industry if we all made recycling a major criterion. It may be impossible simply to refuse to buy any product when the manufacturer or dealer has no recycling scheme, but that is the direction in which we should head. Will I buy a Nokia when my beloved Sony Ericsson finally stops working? Well, Nokia will certainly be high on my list, and I shall enquire about recycling from whatever manufacturer I do consider. I would encourage everybody to act in this way, and apply good old market forces on the industry and try to bring about a proper recycling culture.

For my part, I shall certainly continue to ask every single hardware vendor that I meet just what provisions they have made for recycling, and this is an issue to which Digit will often return.

The only problem left unresolved in my mind, is this. How on earth do you recycle Al Gore...?

E. Henning

edward.henning@9dot9.in



Edward Henning, Editor-in-Chief

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